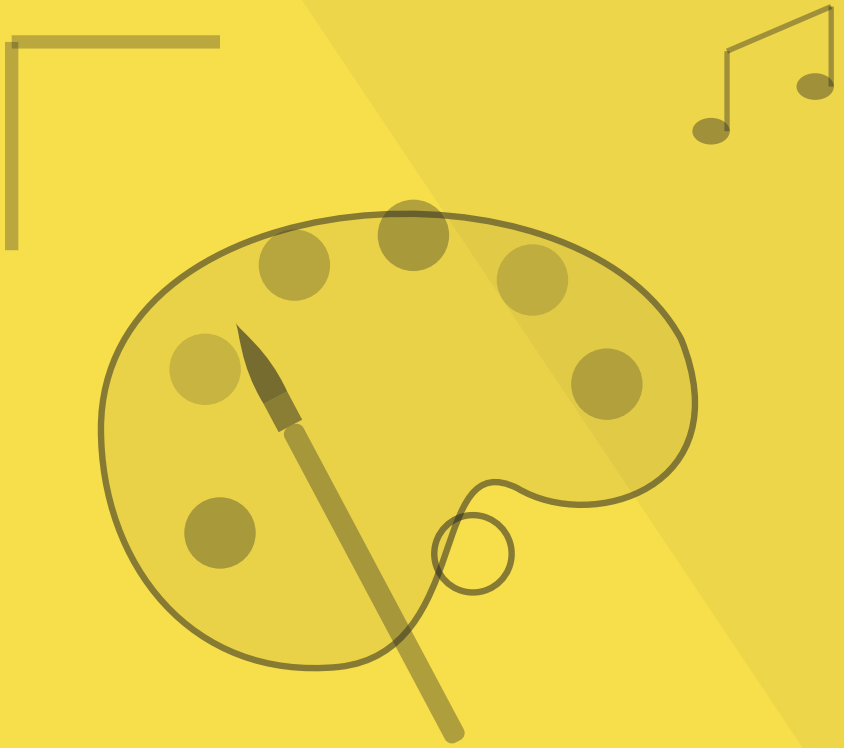
VENVLEARNING

STUDENT TEXTBOOK



Art

GRADE 4

Lessons, examples, and practice for the whole year

2026–2027 School Year · Unit 1: The Elements of Art

VENVLEARNING

Grade 4
Art

STUDENT TEXTBOOK

2026–2027 School Year

Unit 1 The Elements of Art

This book belongs to _____

A VenvLearning family homeschool curriculum

How to use this book

Each lesson starts with an I can goal and a Look And Wonder question. Read the lesson with your teacher. Read about the idea, study the Step by Step demonstrations, then make art in the Create studio activity. Your practice pages are in your Student Workbook, labeled with the same lesson number.

- Key Idea boxes hold the most important rule or fact. Learn these.
- Watch Out boxes warn you about common mistakes.
- Create boxes are studio activities. Keep everything you make in your portfolio folder.
- Every Friday there is a short Sketchbook Check in your workbook. The last Friday of a unit is the Portfolio Review.

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UNIT 1

The Elements of Art

Looking like an artist, line, shape and form, proportion, color, value and contrast, composition, and revision.

Every artwork, from a cave painting to a cartoon, is built from the same ingredients: line, shape, form, color, value, texture, and space. In this unit you'll learn to look like an artist, then practice each element in your own work, plan a composition, and use feedback to make a finished piece for your portfolio.

In this unit you will…

- Observe and describe art using the elements of art.
- Use line, shape, form, and proportion in drawings.
- Mix colors, make value scales, and use contrast.
- Plan compositions and revise with feedback.

ART IN YOUR WORLD

Designers, illustrators, architects, and photographers use the elements of art every day, and so does anyone who arranges a poster, a room, or a plate of food.

UNIT VOCABULARY

elements of art	Line, shape, form, color, value, texture, space.
proportion	Size relationships.
primary colors	Red, yellow, blue.
contrast	A big difference that stands out.
composition	How parts are arranged.
revise	Change and improve.

Lessons in this unit

Lesson	Title
1.1	Looking Like an Artist

Lesson	Title
1.2	Line
1.3	Shape and Form
1.4	Proportion
1.5	Color
1.6	Value and Contrast
1.7	Composition
1.8	Revision and Kind, Specific Feedback

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.1 · NCAS VA:Re7, VA:Re8

Lesson 1.1: Looking Like an Artist

I can look closely at artwork and describe what I see using the elements of art.

WORDS TO KNOW

elements of art	The building blocks artists use: line, shape, form, color, value, texture, and space.
observe	To look closely and carefully.
artwork	Something an artist makes, such as a painting, sculpture, or print.

LOOK AND WONDER

Look at any picture on your wall for one whole minute without talking. What did you notice in the last 30 seconds that you missed at first?

Artists are expert lookers. Before they make art, they spend a lot of time observing: noticing shapes, colors, and tiny details most people walk past. When we talk about art, we use the elements of art, the building blocks every artist uses.

Element	What it is
line	a mark that moves from one point to another
shape	a flat area with edges (2-D)
form	a shape with depth, like a ball or box (3-D)
color	what we see when light reflects off something: red, blue, yellow, and more
value	how light or dark something is
texture	how something feels, or looks like it would feel
space	the area around, between, and inside things

Walter Anderson (1903–1965) was an artist from Ocean Springs, Mississippi. He rowed a small boat out to Horn Island in the Gulf of Mexico and spent days drawing and painting the birds, crabs, plants, and waves he found there. He looked so closely that his watercolors seem to move. He's a great example of an artist who learned by observing.

STEP BY STEP · SEE, THINK, WONDER

Use these three steps to look at any artwork.

1 See: What do you see? Name only what is really there (colors, lines, objects).

2 Think: What do you think is going on? Why?

3 Wonder: What questions do you have?

Look for: Slow, careful looking first; ideas and questions second.

CREATE · NATURE OBSERVATION SKETCH

How much can you notice in 10 minutes?

You need: pencil; sketchbook or paper; a leaf, flower, shell, or pinecone.

1 Set your object in front of you.

2 Look for one full minute before you draw.

3 Draw it slowly, looking at the object more than at your paper.

4 Add three labels for details you noticed (veins, spots, edges).

Record: your sketch with three labeled details.

KEY IDEA

Artists look closely first. The elements of art (line, shape, form, color, value, texture, space) give us words for what we see.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Name three elements of art.
2. Where did Walter Anderson go to draw nature?
3. What are the three steps of See, Think, Wonder?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.1.

LESSON SUMMARY

Look closely; use the elements of art to describe what you see.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.2 · NCAS VA:Cr1, VA:Cr2

Lesson 1.2: Line

I can create different kinds of lines and use them to show movement and feeling.

WORDS TO KNOW

line	A mark that moves from one point to another.
contour line	A line that shows the outside edge of a shape.
implied line	A line we imagine, like the path your eye follows.

LOOK AND WONDER

Draw a line that looks calm. Now draw a line that looks excited. What's different?

Line is the first element most artists use. Lines can be straight, curved, zigzag, wavy, spiral, dotted, thick, or thin. Lines also carry feelings: flat horizontal lines feel calm and restful, tall vertical lines feel strong, and slanted diagonal lines feel full of movement.



straight curved zigzag wavy spiral dotted thick thin

In The Starry Night (1889), Vincent van Gogh used thick, swirling, curving lines to make the night sky look like it is moving. Find a picture of it online or in a library book and trace the swirls with your finger.

CREATE · LINE SAMPLER AND LINE FEELINGS

How can lines show feelings?

You need: pencil; black marker; paper.

1. Fold a paper into eight boxes.
2. Fill each box with a different kind of line (straight, curved, zigzag, wavy, spiral, dotted, thick, thin).
3. On a new paper, draw a simple landscape using only lines that feel calm.
4. Draw the same landscape again using only lines that feel stormy.

Record: both landscapes and a sentence about which lines you chose.

KEY IDEA

Lines can be many kinds, and their direction and shape carry feeling: horizontal = calm, vertical = strong, diagonal = movement.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. What feeling do horizontal lines often show?
2. What kind of line shows the outside edge of a shape?
3. What kind of lines did van Gogh use in the sky?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.2.

LESSON SUMMARY

Lines vary in type and direction, and they carry feeling.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.3 · NCAS VA:Cr2

Lesson 1.3: Shape and Form

I can tell shapes from forms, sort shapes as geometric or organic, and use shading to make a shape look 3-D.

WORDS TO KNOW

geometric shape	A shape with exact, regular edges, like a circle, square, or triangle.
organic shape	A free-flowing shape like those found in nature, such as a leaf or a puddle.
form	An object with three dimensions: height, width, and depth.
shading	Adding darker values to show where light doesn't reach.

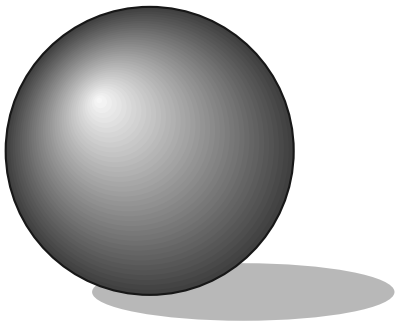
LOOK AND WONDER

Is a circle the same as a ball? How could you draw a circle so it looks like a ball?

Shapes are flat (two-dimensional). Geometric shapes have exact edges; organic shapes are free and irregular, like things in nature. Forms are three-dimensional: a circle becomes a sphere, a square becomes a cube, a triangle becomes a cone or pyramid.

Shape (2-D)	Form (3-D)
circle	sphere (ball)
square	cube (box)
rectangle	cylinder or rectangular prism
triangle	cone or pyramid

In his last years, Henri Matisse “drew with scissors,” cutting bold organic shapes from painted paper, as in The Snail (1953). Artists can also turn a flat shape into a form by shading: darker values on the side away from the light.



Shading turns a flat circle into a round form.

CREATE · FROM SHAPE TO FORM

How can shading make a shape look three-dimensional?

You need: pencil; paper; a ball or orange and a lamp or window light.

1. Draw a circle. Decide where the light is coming from.
2. Shade the side away from the light darker, blending smoothly.
3. Leave a small bright spot (highlight) near the light side.
4. Add a shadow on the ground under the ball.

Record: your shaded sphere and a flat circle side by side.

KEY IDEA

Shapes are flat; forms have depth. Shading on the side away from the light turns a shape into a form.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Geometric or organic: a leaf

2. What form does a circle become?
3. Where does shading go?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.3.

LESSON SUMMARY

Shapes are flat; shading makes forms look 3-D.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.4 · NCAS VA:Cr2, VA:Cr3

Lesson 1.4: Proportion

I can use proportion to draw a face with parts in the right size and place.

WORDS TO KNOW

proportion	How the sizes of parts compare with each other and with the whole.
scale	The size of something compared with something else.
portrait	A picture of a person, often the face.

LOOK AND WONDER

Where are your eyes on your head: near the top, or halfway down? Make a guess, then check in a mirror with a ruler.

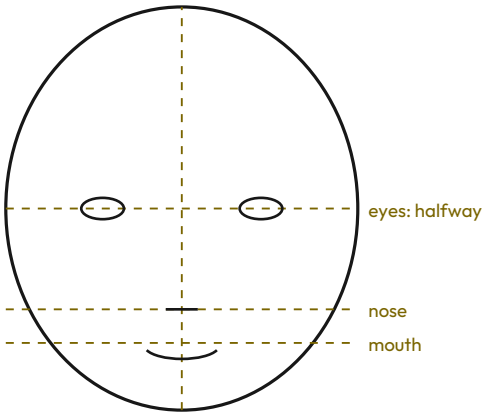
Proportion means the size relationships between parts. Most people draw eyes too high! On most faces, the eyes are about halfway between the top of the head and the chin. Artists use guidelines to place features.

Face guide: draw an oval. A line halfway down shows where the eyes go.

The bottom of the nose is about halfway between the eyes and the chin.

The mouth is about one-third of the way from the nose to the chin.

Eyes are about one eye-width apart.



Artists sometimes break proportion on purpose. Cartoonists draw big heads and huge eyes to look cute or funny. That's called exaggeration.

CREATE · PROPORTIONAL SELF-PORTRAIT

Can guidelines help you draw a face that looks right?

You need: pencil; eraser; mirror; paper.

1. Draw a large oval. Lightly draw the halfway line and a center line.
2. Place the eyes on the halfway line, one eye-width apart.
3. Add the nose and mouth using the guide.
4. Look in the mirror to add hair, ears (between the eye line and nose line), and details.
5. Erase the guidelines.

Record: your self-portrait.

KEY IDEA

Proportion is size relationships. Eyes sit about halfway down the head.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Where are the eyes on most faces?
2. Where do the ears usually line up?
3. What is exaggeration?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.4.

LESSON SUMMARY

Use guidelines: eyes halfway, nose and mouth below.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.5 · NCAS VA:Cr2

Lesson 1.5: Color

I can name primary, secondary, and tertiary colors and mix secondary colors.

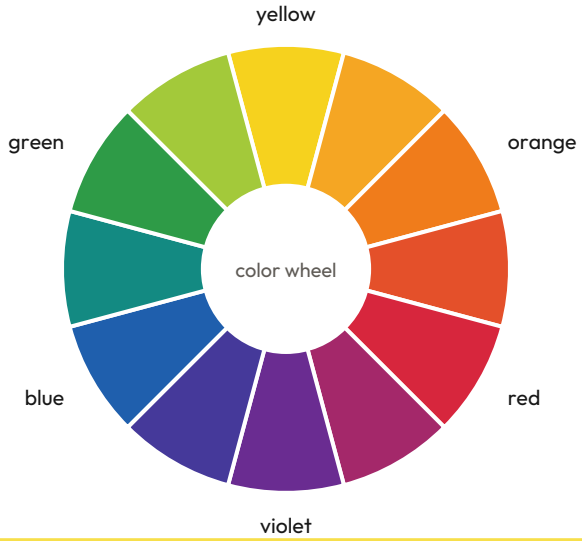
WORDS TO KNOW

primary colors	Red, yellow, and blue: colors that can't be made by mixing other paints.
secondary colors	Orange, green, and violet: made by mixing two primary colors.
tertiary colors	Colors made by mixing a primary and a neighboring secondary color, like blue-green.
color wheel	A circle that shows how colors relate.

LOOK AND WONDER

If you only had red, yellow, and blue paint, how many colors could you make?

The painter's color wheel starts with three primary colors: red, yellow, and blue. Mix two primaries to get a secondary color: red + yellow = orange, yellow + blue = green, blue + red = violet. Mix a primary with a neighboring secondary to get a tertiary color, such as yellow-green or red-violet.



STEP BY STEP · MIX A SECONDARY COLOR

Make green.

1. Put a small puddle of yellow on your palette.
2. Add a tiny bit of blue and mix. (Blue is strong; add it a little at a time.)
3. Keep adding blue until you like the green.

Look for: Start with the lighter color and add the darker color slowly.

CREATE · PAINT A COLOR WHEEL

Can you make every color on the wheel from three primaries?

You need: red, yellow, and blue paint; brush; water cup; paper towel; paper plate palette; the workbook color wheel template.

1. Paint the three primary colors in their spaces.
2. Mix and paint the three secondary colors.
3. Mix and paint the six tertiary colors.
4. Clean your brush between colors.

Record: your finished 12-part color wheel.

KEY IDEA

Primary colors mix to make secondary colors; primary + neighboring secondary makes tertiary colors.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Red + yellow = ?
2. Name the three primary colors.
3. Name a tertiary color.

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.5.

LESSON SUMMARY

Primaries mix into secondaries and tertiaries on the color wheel.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.6 · NCAS VA:Cr2, VA:Re7

Lesson 1.6: Value and Contrast

I can make tints and shades, create a value scale, and use contrast to make something stand out.

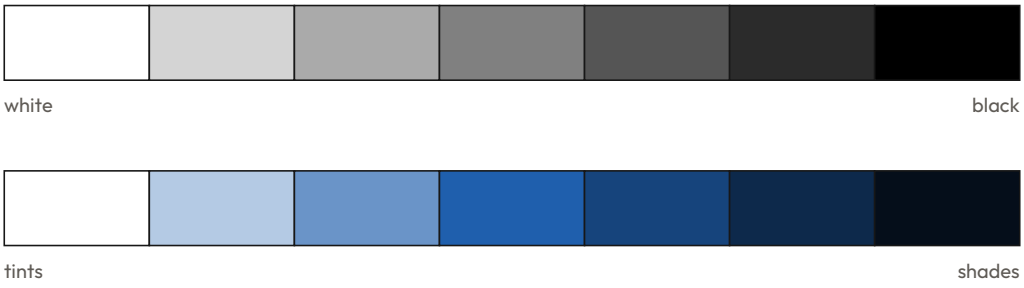
WORDS TO KNOW

value	How light or dark a color is.
tint	A color made lighter by adding white.
shade	A color made darker by adding black.
contrast	A big difference between parts, such as light next to dark.
complementary colors	Colors opposite each other on the color wheel.

LOOK AND WONDER

Why are stop signs red and white, and school buses yellow and black?

Value is lightness or darkness. Add white to make a tint; add black to make a shade. A value scale shows the steps from light to dark.



Tints and shades of blue.

Contrast is a big difference, and it grabs attention. Light next to dark is high contrast. Complementary colors, which sit opposite each other on the color wheel (red and green, blue and orange, yellow and violet), also make strong contrast.

CREATE · HIGH-CONTRAST PICTURE

How can contrast make one thing stand out?

You need: paint or colored pencils; black and white paint or pencils; paper.

1. Make a 5-step value scale of one color, from tint to shade.
2. Draw a simple subject (a fish, a flower, a rocket).
3. Color the subject with one color and the background with its complement.

4 Check: does your subject pop out?

Record: your value scale and your high-contrast picture.

KEY IDEA

Tints are lighter, shades are darker; contrast (light vs dark, or complements) makes things stand out.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. What do you add to make a tint?
2. What is the complement of blue?
3. Why are school buses yellow and black?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.6.

LESSON SUMMARY

Value is light and dark; contrast makes parts stand out.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.7 · NCAS VA:Cr1, VA:Cr2

Lesson 1.7: Composition

I can plan a composition with a clear focal point and balance.

WORDS TO KNOW

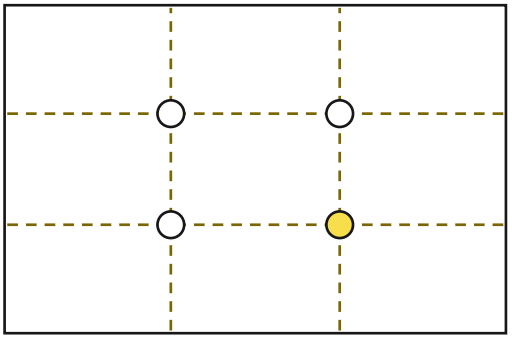
composition	How the parts of an artwork are arranged.
focal point	The part of an artwork your eye goes to first.
balance	How visual weight is spread out; symmetrical or asymmetrical.
thumbnail sketch	A small, quick drawing to plan an idea.

LOOK AND WONDER

When you take a photo, do you always put the main thing right in the middle? What happens if you don't?

Composition is how an artist arranges everything in the picture. A strong composition has a focal point, the spot your eye goes to first, and balance. Symmetrical balance is the same on both sides; asymmetrical balance uses different things that feel equally weighted.

Many artists place the focal point a little off center. Divide the picture into thirds both ways; the four places where the lines cross are strong spots for a focal point.



In The Great Wave off Kanagawa (about 1831), the Japanese artist Katsushika Hokusai placed a huge curling wave on the left and a tiny Mount Fuji low in the middle, framed by the wave.

CREATE · THUMBNAIL PLANNING

Which arrangement makes the strongest picture?

You need: pencil; paper.

1. Choose a subject: your pet, your house, or a favorite place.
2. Draw four small boxes (thumbnails).
3. Sketch the subject a different way in each: centered, off center, close up, far away.
4. Circle the strongest one and explain why.

Record: four thumbnails with your choice circled.

KEY IDEA

Plan the arrangement: choose a focal point (often off center), balance the picture, and try ideas small first.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. What is a focal point?
2. What kind of balance is the same on both sides?
3. What is a thumbnail sketch?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.7.

LESSON SUMMARY

Plan with thumbnails; choose a focal point and balance.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.8 · NCAS VA:Cr3, VA:Re9

Lesson 1.8: Revision and Kind, Specific Feedback

I can give and use kind, specific, helpful feedback to improve my artwork.

WORDS TO KNOW

revise	To change and improve your work.
feedback	Comments that help someone improve.
critique	A thoughtful discussion of artwork.

LOOK AND WONDER

What's more helpful: “It's good!” or “The eyes look great; maybe make the background darker so your face stands out”?

Artists rarely get it right the first time. They make drafts, get feedback, and revise. Good feedback is kind (respectful), specific (names exactly what to look at), and helpful (gives an idea to try).

In a well-known video called Austin's Butterfly, a first grader named Austin draws a butterfly six times. After each draft, classmates give kind, specific feedback, and his final drawing is amazingly detailed. Watch it with your teacher if you can.

Instead of…	Try…
“I like it.”	“I like how your wavy lines make the water look like it's moving.”
“It's bad.”	“The house is small; could you make it bigger so it's the focal point?”
“Fix the colors.”	“Try a complementary color behind the bird so it stands out.”

CREATE · DRAFT, FEEDBACK, FINAL

How much can feedback improve a drawing?

You need: your best thumbnail from Lesson 1.7; paper; colored pencils or paint.

1. Make a larger draft from your thumbnail.
2. Ask your teacher or a family member for one kind, specific, helpful comment.
3. Revise based on the feedback.

4 Add color, using value and contrast.

5 Put your draft and final side by side.

Record: your draft, the feedback, and your final piece for your portfolio.

KEY IDEA

Kind, specific, helpful feedback plus revision makes art (and everything else) better.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Talk it over with your teacher or answer in your sketchbook.

1. Name the three parts of good feedback.
2. What did Austin do to improve his butterfly?
3. What does revise mean?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.8.

LESSON SUMMARY

Get kind, specific, helpful feedback, then revise.

UNIT 1 REVIEW

Unit 1 Study Guide

Use this page to get ready for the unit test. Read each big idea, then try the review pages in your workbook.

Lesson	Remember…
1.1	Look closely; use the elements of art to describe what you see.
1.2	Lines vary in type and direction, and they carry feeling.
1.3	Shapes are flat; shading makes forms look 3-D.
1.4	Use guidelines: eyes halfway, nose and mouth below.
1.5	Primaries mix into secondaries and tertiaries on the color wheel.
1.6	Value is light and dark; contrast makes parts stand out.
1.7	Plan with thumbnails; choose a focal point and balance.
1.8	Get kind, specific, helpful feedback, then revise.

Glossary

artwork	Something an artist makes, such as a painting, sculpture, or print.
balance	How visual weight is spread out; symmetrical or asymmetrical.
color wheel	A circle that shows how colors relate.
complementary colors	Colors opposite each other on the color wheel.
composition	How parts are arranged.
contour line	A line that shows the outside edge of a shape.
contrast	A big difference that stands out.
critique	A thoughtful discussion of artwork.
elements of art	Line, shape, form, color, value, texture, space.
feedback	Comments that help someone improve.
focal point	The part of an artwork your eye goes to first.
form	An object with three dimensions: height, width, and depth.
geometric shape	A shape with exact, regular edges, like a circle, square, or triangle.
implied line	A line we imagine, like the path your eye follows.
line	A mark that moves from one point to another.
observe	To look closely and carefully.
organic shape	A free-flowing shape like those found in nature, such as a leaf or a puddle.
portrait	A picture of a person, often the face.
primary colors	Red, yellow, blue.
proportion	Size relationships.
revise	Change and improve.
scale	The size of something compared with something else.
secondary colors	Orange, green, and violet: made by mixing two primary colors.
shade	A color made darker by adding black.
shading	Adding darker values to show where light doesn't reach.
tertiary colors	Colors made by mixing a primary and a neighboring secondary color, like blue-green.
thumbnail sketch	A small, quick drawing to plan an idea.
tint	A color made lighter by adding white.

value	How light or dark a color is.

Grade 4 Art

Student Textbook · 2026–2027

A full year of Grade 4 arts: drawing, painting, and design; music; art history; theater and dance; media arts; and sculpture. Every lesson pairs looking closely at real artwork with hands-on studio time, and the year ends with a portfolio and a show.

This Student Textbook teaches every lesson: the big idea, key vocabulary, models and examples, and a short set of practice problems to check understanding. It pairs with the Student Workbook and the Teacher Edition.

INSIDE THIS YEAR

01 The Elements of Art

IN THIS BOOK

- Clear lesson goals: “I can…” statements
- Key vocabulary with student-friendly definitions
- Models, examples, and Key Idea summaries
- A study guide and glossary for every unit

THE COMPLETE SET



Textbook
You are holding this book

Workbook

Teacher Edition

Each lesson has the same number in all three books, and every day of the year is mapped to its lesson in the VenvLearning planner.